

CHAPTER 1 — Late Again

The warm coastal breeze drifted through the half-open window of Elias's bedroom, carrying the faint smell of the city: exhaust, damp brick, and the metallic tang of the fire escape clinging to the building like an old scar.

On Saturdays, smoke from the food stalls below usually softened it. Fish on hot iron. Garlic. Charred lemon. One decent smell in a neighbourhood that had stopped trying to impress anyone.

He lived on the fifth floor, though the view never showed it. The rust-eaten staircase blocked everything except a narrow strip of sky.

Even height didn't guarantee freedom.

Elias lay across torn bedsheets in yesterday's clothes. Ten hours of unconscious escape had left him stiff but not rested. His head felt thick—not hungover, not high—just the dull fog of staying clean while his brain remembered the old rhythm.

A tapping started.

Soft at first, then sharper.

A rhythm that did not belong to the room.

He opened his eyes.

Two pigeons strutted along the ledge, stamping their feet with the self-importance only pigeons possessed. They bobbed and cooed, each keeping one beady eye fixed on him through the glass.

Great. Woken by flying rats. Again.

One pecked the window.

The other watched, offering supervision.

Elias pushed himself upright.

His ribs objected first. A dull pressure beneath the left side, old enough to have lost any claim to surprise. His right shoulder followed. The gym

had not caused either problem, but it had reminded both of them that they existed.

The imitation fireplace glowed with fake orange coals beneath the mantel. It had no heat setting that worked, but Elias kept switching it on because the movement looked convincing from across the room.

On the mantel, an old round-faced clock leaned slightly to one side, its twin bells raised like judgemental eyebrows.

He checked the time.

Ten hours of sleep.

He had set the alarm for seven.

It was eight.

Perfect. Late again, and I look like I just crawled out of a dustbin.

The alarm clock had not failed.

A small red switch on the back showed that he had turned it off sometime during the night.

Elias did not remember doing it.

He rubbed his face.

The pigeons continued their meeting without him.

Beside the bed, the top drawer stood open by an inch.

Inside it lay a blister strip of immediate-release oxycodone, two tablets missing from a row of ten. The doctor had prescribed them after the pain beneath his ribs became bad enough to interfere with driving.

Elias had taken the first two exactly as instructed.

They had worked.

That was the problem.

The pain had receded. He had slept. In the morning, his body had remembered how easily a tablet could turn endurance back into function.

He had been here before, years earlier, when another legitimate prescription had quietly become something his body expected. He had stopped eventually—too quickly, alone, and badly enough never to forget it.

The remaining eight had stayed in the drawer ever since.

Elias pushed it shut.

That counted.

Not as victory. Victory implied the argument had ended.

It counted as another morning.

He stood slowly, waited for the room to settle and stretched until the pressure beneath his ribs reduced to something manageable. The flat was cold despite the false fire. A mug from yesterday stood on the windowsill beside an unopened electricity bill. Two shirts hung from the back of a chair. A stack of clean clothes remained folded on the sofa because putting them away would have required deciding which drawers were still usable.

The place looked neglected.

It was not dirty.

Elias understood the difference even if nobody else would have cared.

The kitchen sink was empty. The worktops were wiped. Every lock worked. The torch beside the front door had fresh batteries. The old tools in the hall cupboard were cleaned, charged and arranged by size.

His life could decay.

Equipment could not.

He crossed to the bathroom, turned on the shower and received three seconds of hot water before it surrendered.

“Excellent.”

He washed quickly, dressed in the least creased shirt available and found one clean sock inside a shoe.

The second was beneath the sofa.

He did not ask why.

Coffee took less thought.

Three spoons. No sugar. Water just below boiling because the kettle switch had broken and now required supervision. He drank half of it standing at the kitchen counter and poured the rest into a travel mug with a lid that no longer sealed properly.

On the table lay a white envelope.

He had written Mac's name on the front the previous night.

Inside was a short notice letter containing seven sentences. Elias had rewritten it four times and disliked every version.

The final one said little:

I will complete work already accepted. I will not take further assignments after Friday. Please arrange final payment.

No explanation.

No apology.

No accusation.

He had learned that explanations gave people handles.

The envelope went into the inside pocket of his jacket.

Today.

He would give it to Mac today.

Before another late-night collection. Before another passenger who did not want to say where they had been. Before another sealed package that moved when the car turned too sharply.

Driving had been clean work when he started.

A route.

A pickup.

A destination.

Mac had understood the arrangement. Elias drove. Mac paid. Neither asked the other for a history.

Over time, the jobs had changed by degrees small enough to ignore separately.

A passenger collected from a rear entrance instead of a front one.

Cash delivered in an envelope.

A vehicle moved between two garages without paperwork.

A young man with blood on one cuff who insisted he had cut himself shaving.

Nothing Elias could prove.

Nothing he had wanted to prove.

That had been the point of the job.

He had spent years learning how not to know things.

The clock on the mantel advanced another minute.

Elias grabbed his keys.

The pigeons watched him leave.

"Flat's yours," he told them.

One pecked the glass again.

* * *

The corridor outside smelled of old carpet, furniture polish and someone's breakfast burning two floors below.

The walls were painted dull brown and trimmed with gold leaf that tried and failed to look expensive. Antique light fittings hung too low for the narrow space, casting more shadow than illumination.

The lift indicator showed fifteen.

Of course it did.

Elias pressed the call button once.

Nothing happened.

He pressed it again, not because that would help but because disappointment sometimes required confirmation.

The number remained fifteen.

He took the stairs.

His legs remembered the rhythm even when the rest of him did not. Two steps at a time until the third floor, then one where the turn tightened and the concrete had cracked near the railing.

Twenty years in the building had made the stairwell part of his nervous system.

He knew which doors closed softly.

Which children left bicycles across the landing.

Which neighbour smoked through the bathroom vent and blamed the plumbing.

When Elias first moved in, the block had been full of young families. Affordable housing, the council had called it. It did what it said on the tin.

It also gave local children a hobby.

They raced up the stairwell, pressed the lift button on every floor and trapped residents in a thirty-minute vertical tour of the building. If you lived near the top, you saw the same two grinning faces at every stop.

Most of those children had grown up and left.

Some had not gone far.

Elias still recognised them in adults carrying shopping, pushing prams or arguing on the phone in the same corners where they had once hidden from school.

On the third-floor landing, Mrs Doran stood outside her flat with a wheeled shopping trolley and a door that refused to close.

She was small, silver-haired and dressed for weather several degrees colder than the actual morning.

"You're late," she said.

Elias stopped.

"You've been speaking to Mac."

"I've been hearing you run down these stairs for nineteen years."

"Twenty."

"Then you've been late longer than I thought."

She pulled the door. It moved halfway and caught against the frame.

"The hinge has dropped again," Elias said.

"I know what it's done."

"Then why are you attacking the handle?"

"Because the hinge won't listen."

Elias placed his coffee on the floor and lifted the door by the handle while pushing it inward. The lower hinge settled. The lock met the frame.

Mrs Doran tested it twice.

"You should tell housing."

"I did."

"What did they say?"

"They gave me a reference number."

"Useful."

"I'm thinking of framing it."

Elias picked up the travel mug.

Mrs Doran looked at his jacket.

“Work?”

“For the moment.”

She did not ask what that meant.

People in the building had learned not to ask questions Elias might answer honestly.

He carried the shopping trolley down two flights for her despite the fact that she was going up later and would need it brought back. At the lobby, she took the handle from him.

“You still have my screwdriver,” he said.

“You gave it to me.”

“I lent it.”

“That was in 2019.”

“So you admit possession.”

Mrs Doran pushed through the outer door.

“Go to work, Elias.”

He watched until she reached the pavement.

Then he checked his watch.

Later again.

He did not regret stopping.

That irritated him.

* * *

The lobby retained traces of the building it had once hoped to become.

Chequered tile.

A dark oak reception desk nobody had staffed in years.

Brass numbers above pigeon-hole mail slots.

Elias's box was full.

It had been full for months.

Someone had once removed the letters, tied them with an elastic band and left them outside his flat. Elias had carried them downstairs the next morning and returned them to the box unopened.

The gesture had been repeated twice before the unknown neighbour accepted defeat.

Today, one white envelope protruded through the slot.

FINAL NOTICE showed above the fold.

Elias pushed it back inside.

The envelope in his jacket pressed against his chest.

Quitting did not pay bills.

Neither did staying clean.

Both cost money in ways nobody advertised.

He left the building.

The morning air was cool and sharp. Across the courtyard, delivery shutters opened beneath the flats. A cyclist balanced a paper cup in one hand and nearly lost it on the kerb. The woman from the second floor stood beside the bus stop with her terrier, exactly where she stood every weekday at eight fifteen.

Elias noticed the pattern and resented himself for noticing.

He no longer looked for threats.

Not deliberately.

His mind catalogued movement before he could tell it not to.

Green delivery van outside the bakery.

Blue hatchback with one brake light out.

Man in grey coat reading a message without slowing.

Terrier pulling towards discarded food.

Nothing wrong.

That was what ordinary life looked like when it was allowed to remain ordinary.

The car park was on the next street.

If traffic behaved, Elias might still reach Mac's office before the morning meeting ended.

Traffic behaving.

That'll be the day.

He turned the corner.

Stopped.

A bright yellow sticker had been slapped across his windscreen.

A clamp hugged the front wheel.

Elias stared at it.

"You have got to be joking."

No good deed goes unpunished.

The silver hatchback occupied the same numbered space it had occupied the previous evening. The permit remained fixed inside the windscreen. The registration on the yellow notice matched the car. The alleged location did not.

The enforcement officer had entered the adjacent street.

Elias read it twice.

Then a third time, because anger occasionally improved through evidence.

It did not.

He crouched and touched the cold metal.

Locked tight.

He had argued with one of the enforcement officers the previous month after the man tried to ticket a nurse unloading groceries for an elderly resident. The argument had ended with the officer promising that Elias would regret interfering.

Apparently municipal revenge operated on a delayed schedule.

Elias took out his phone and photographed:

- the permit; - the bay number; - the clamp; - the notice; - the street sign behind the vehicle; - and the incorrect location printed on the sticker.

He uploaded the photographs to a folder named PARKING NONSENSE.

The folder already contained eleven items.

Then he opened the boot.

Beneath a folded blanket and a container of engine oil sat a compact battery-powered angle grinder inside a hard plastic case.

The battery showed three bars.

Elias checked the cutting disc before switching it on.

The grinder roared to life.

Sparks scattered across the pavement.

A man on the opposite side of the street glanced over, frowned and immediately found something more interesting to look at.

People minded their business.

Good.

Elias cut only the replaceable locking arm, not the wheel housing or the pavement anchor. The clamp gave way with a heavy clunk.

He switched off the grinder and waited for the disc to stop completely before setting it down.

Anger did not excuse poor tool handling.

The man across the road looked again.

Elias lifted the separated clamp, placed both pieces neatly beside the wall beneath the parking sign and photographed them too.

Then he removed the battery from the grinder, returned the tool to its case and put it back in the boot.

Tools lasted longer when they were not treated like emotions.

He tore the sticker from the windscreen, folded it once and placed it in the passenger footwell instead of throwing it away.

Evidence first.

Rage later.

The hatchback's engine coughed twice before settling into its usual rough idle.

Elias sat behind the wheel and tested the brake.

The car smelled faintly of old fabric, coffee and the pine air freshener he had bought three years earlier. The cardboard tree had long since stopped contributing anything except shape.

He checked the clock.

Late.

Clamped.

Pigeons.

Fantastic start.

* * *

Broadway was designed by someone who believed traffic should be punished for existing.

Oversized speed humps appeared every fifty yards. Elias crossed each one at an angle to protect shock absorbers his mechanic had described as “not dead, but planning ahead.”

Shop shutters rolled upwards as he passed.

A bus hissed at a stop.

A cyclist swore at a taxi.

The city woke in fragments, each person attempting to reach somewhere without acknowledging that anybody else had made the same plan.

The first set of lights turned red when Elias was nine cars back.

Five minutes passed.

The light changed.

Three vehicles crossed before red returned.

“What a bloody piss-take.”

His coffee leaked through the damaged lid and ran over two fingers.

He placed the mug in the cup holder and wiped his hand against his trousers.

Four more cars passed at the next change.

Red again.

This road hates me.

A reminder appeared on his phone.

INSURANCE RENEWAL — TODAY

He dismissed it.

Another replaced it.

RENT — OVERDUE

He dismissed that too.

A third notification showed a missed call from the clinic that managed his prescription.

That one remained on screen longer.

Elias turned the phone face down.

The clinic called every month.

He attended often enough to remain on the list and missed often enough to avoid being known by anyone there. The counsellor assigned to him had changed twice. Each new person asked him to explain what staying clean meant.

Elias had never found an answer that sounded true aloud.

It meant not opening the drawer.

It meant going to the gym when sleep would not come.

It meant leaving certain streets before certain doors became visible.

It meant refusing work that required the person he had once been.

That final part had become difficult.

Mac did not know the whole history.

Nobody did.

But Mac had noticed what Elias could do when a journey became complicated. Once a useful skill was seen, employers developed reasons to need it again.

The envelope inside his jacket rested against his ribs.

He would give it to Mac.

Today.

The light changed.

Elias moved with the queue.

Sirens rose from the right.

A police car shot through the junction, followed by an ambulance and another police car. Elias stamped on the brake. The seat belt caught his bruised ribs and turned the old ache sharp.

He waited until the emergency vehicles cleared.

Three vehicles.

Same direction.

Same urgency.

The second police car carried no visible collision equipment. The ambulance travelled between them rather than behind.

Elias watched until buildings concealed the convoy.

Probably nothing.

The signal turned red again.

A horn sounded behind him.

He lifted one hand without looking back.

His phone vibrated violently in the cup holder, rattling as though it wanted out. The X-Files theme whistled through the car.

Only one person had that ringtone.

Mac had selected it himself after hearing Elias describe one of his assignments as badly written fiction.

The contact name on the screen read:

MR PRESIDENT

Elias answered.

"Sir, I'm sorry. Traffic's a nightmare this morning. I'm—"

"Elias. Don't come to the office."

Mac's voice carried no greeting and no interest in the explanation.

Elias stopped speaking.

The white envelope inside his jacket suddenly felt heavier.

"I need you at the airport," Mac said. "Immediately."

"I'm twenty minutes from the office."

"You're closer to the airport than anyone else I trust."

That was an unusual word for Mac.

Trust normally meant payment received, instruction followed, no questions asked.

"What happened to the assigned driver?"

"Unavailable."

"Meaning?"

"Meaning you are driving."

Elias watched the red light burn in front of him.

"What am I collecting?"

"My niece."

He looked at the phone although Mac was not visible on it.

"Your niece."

"Zoe. Thirteen. Travelling alone."

Elias lowered the volume of the car radio, though it had not been on.

"You've never mentioned a niece."

"I have several relatives I don't discuss with employees."

"Since when am I an employee?"

"Since you started complaining like one."

The answer arrived smoothly enough to have been prepared.

Mac continued.

"She has had a difficult journey. She is upset. I've sent her your photograph. I'll send you hers and the address you're taking her to."

"Where are her parents?"

"With family."

"That doesn't answer the question."

A pause.

Half a second.

Long enough.

"Take her to her grandmother," Mac said. "That is all you need to know."

A horn sounded behind Elias again.

The light had changed.

He did not move.

"Why is she travelling alone?"

Mac's voice lost what little patience it had contained.

"Because the adults responsible for her made that arrangement. Your part is simpler. Find her. Keep her safe. Drive."

The final word carried the shape of an old agreement.

Elias drove.

Mac paid.

Neither asked.

The envelope in Elias's jacket pressed against his chest.

He could say no.

He had said no to worse work.

He had walked away from money when the route felt wrong, when the passenger carried fear instead of luggage, when Mac described a person as property by accident and then corrected himself.

But thirteen was not luggage.

A child alone at an airport was not a sealed package he could refuse to collect and forget.

Mac knew that.

The knowledge irritated Elias more than the instruction.

"What flight?" he asked.

"I'll send it."

"Full name?"

"Zoe Harper."

The surname sounded too ordinary to reassure him.

"Does she know who I am?"

"She has your photograph."

"That wasn't the question."

"It is enough."

Mac ended the call.

The green light remained ahead of Elias.

The driver behind leaned on the horn.

Elias put the car into gear and moved through the junction.

His phone buzzed once.

A flight number appeared.

Then a message:

She may be difficult. Do not take it personally.

A second message followed.

An address three hours from the airport.

No photograph yet.

No family contact.

No explanation for the changed driver.

Elias read the address at the next red light.

A house outside the city.

Residential road.

Nothing remarkable in the map preview.

That did not mean anything.

Respectable houses had doors too.

He opened the navigation app and selected the airport.

The route changed.

The blue line turned away from Mac's office, carrying the unopened notice letter with it.

Elias touched the edge of the envelope through his jacket.

Friday, he had written.

Complete work already accepted.

This job had not been accepted when he wrote it.

He could turn around.

He could call Mac back.

He could place the resignation letter through the office door and let the airport solve its own problem.

Instead, he indicated left.

Not for Mac.

That distinction mattered to him.

It would not matter to anyone else.

The city thinned ahead.

Warehouses replaced shops.

Chain-link fencing began beside the road.

Somewhere beyond it, a thirteen-year-old girl was waiting for a photograph to become a person.

Elias drove towards her.